The League of Semi-Superheroes

By Val Smith and Michael Bigelow Dixon

CAROL'S VOICE (on the answering machine):

Hello. You have reached the number of the League of Semi-Superheroes. If this is an emergency, please stay on the line and an operator will pick up shortly. (pause) If this is a message for only The Human Puddle, please press "1" now. If this is a message for Wabbit Woman, please press "2" now. (pause) If this is a message for Master of the Obvious, please press "3" now. (pause) If this is a message for El Grande De Sayer DE Nay, (pause) don't bother to press anything. If this is a message for Pushy Bob, press "4". and get out of the way. (pause) If this is a message for the entire League, please leave it at the tone----

(The League leans in eagerly to listen. The sound of the tone. There is the sound of snorts and giggles, and then a hang-up,)

INTRODUCTION

In a world of semi-terror and almost confusion, only one league of nearly-heroes can save us. Meet El Grande De Sayer De Nay, Master of the Obvious, Pushy Bob, Wabbit Woman, The Human Puddle, and Carol, the league Receptionist . . . Together they make up THE LEAGUE OF SEMI-SUPERHEROES by Val Smith and Michael Bigelow Dixon. . . If they were brave enough to answer the phone . . . Everyone would know who they are!

EL GRANDE DE SAYER DE NAY: Told ya.

THE HUMAN PUDDLE: It could have been something. It might have been something.

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EL GRANDE DE SAYER DE NAY: They only call 'cause they think we're a joke.

(Human Puddle bursts into tears.)

MASTER OF THE OBVIOUS: You've upset The Puddle.

EL GRANDE DE SAYER DE NAY: So what else is new?

WABBIT WOMAN: (she sings) "Rain Drops are Falling on My Head"

PUSHY BOB: So! Carol, whaddaya doin'? What are you working on there?

CAROL: (working on her crossword puzzle.) Oh, I don't know, Pushy Bob. What does it look like to you?

MASTER OF THE OBVIOUS: Say, isn't that a crossword puzzle you've got there?

CAROL: I'm surrounded. I give up.

PUSHY BOB: (looking over Carol's shoulder) Oh, way-way-way-way-wait! Forty-four down, a five letter word for "screw-up"! Hold on, hold on. No, hold on now, hold on! Ahhhhhhh—

CAROL: (grabbing crossword puzzle back from Pushy Bob.) Look! Instead of working MY crossword puzzle, why don't we deal with your bills? For instance. Here. The bank statement. Oh, my. Surprise, surprise. You're overdrawn on all your accounts.

MASTER OF THE OBVIOUS: Ooh bummer.

CAROL: Exactly. Ooh bummer. And what is this? Why, it's an eviction notice from the landlord. Oh dear. What should you do? Any semi-super money to take care of this? Any semi-super ideas? Any ideas at all? (an embarrassed silence among the Semi-Superheroes.) No? Well then, there's a little matter of my salary. You are familiar with the word "salary?" Money in exchange for work provided?

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MASTER OF THE OBVIOUS: Ah c'mon Carol. We know what salary means.

PUSHY BOB: Hey, we'll write you a check!

CAROL: I'll start clearing out my desk.

MASTER OF THE OBVIOUS: Our bank account is overdrawn. (Carol begins emptying out her desk, collecting her personal belongings in a box. Pushy Bob hovers around her, checking out her stuff.)

WABBIT WOMAN: Hizth izzth ridiculuzzz! They can't take away our office, for cwying out wowed. How will we do ouh bidness?

EL GRANDE DE SAYER: Look around, Wabbit Woman. Don't you see? Oh, c'mon! All of you? Any of you? Don't you see?

WABBIT WOMAN: Well. We're wookin'—

EL GRANDE DE SAYER: I'm speaking metaphorically!

MASTER OF THE OBVIOUS: No fair! You can't expect me to figure that out.

WABBIT WOMAN: He's Master of the Obvious.

EL GRANDE DE SAYER: Don't you see, it isn't working! We have no business! In a year, nobody has called for our services. It can't work! It will never work! Never ,never, never!

(The Human Puddle sobs loudly.)

MASTER OF THE OBVIOUS: Geez. There goes The Puddle.

EL GRANDE: Oh what else is new!

PUSHY BOB: Look out everybody! The glass is half empty again.

EL GRANDE: This time it's complete empty. We're being evicted. Carol is thinking of leaving.

CAROL: Correction. Carol is leaving. (To Pushy Bob.) Will you please get out of the way!

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PUSHY BOB: Okay! Have a big gigantic din-dong-cow!

EL GRANDE: I mean, who are we kidding? "Semi-Super Heroes!" Our talents make no sense!

CAROL: Finally. Thank you, God.

THE HUMAN PUDDLE: Ordinary people with "unusual" skills helping other people in need.

MASTER OF THE OBVIOUS: That was the whole idea.

EL GRANDE: Sounds good, Human Puddle. Only one problem. Who needs stupid skills?

WABBIT WOMAN: Ma skiffs ant stoofid! Can you smoke, snorkel AND smirk? I can!

EL GRANDE: Who cares?

MASTER OF THE OBVIOUS: It may not be obvious to everyone but even if it is—doesn't it follow, El Grande de Sayer de Nay, that you also have a stupid skill? Hmmmmmmmmmmmmmmmm?!

EL GRANDE: NO!

CAROL: Guys, there's one more piece of…

PUSHY BOB: Look! Right now, somebody out there might need a push guy! And if I can help by bulldozing my way in somewhere, hey—I'm there!

THE HUMAN PUDDLE: Or jus someone who likes to—who can't help—crying—

(The Human Puddle sobs uncontrollably.)

CAROL: Guys, you're not listening.

WABBIT WOMAN: We're wisionaries!

EL GRANDE: We're The League of Personality Disorders!

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MASTER OF THE OBVIOUS: Some people choose not to see it that way. While others obviously do.

PUSHY BOB: I've always thought we could use more aggressive advertising. Loud and In Your Face.

WABBIT WOMAN: Yah! Willlwe Wowed!

PUSHY BOB: Yeah! Willlwe willlwe Wowed!

CAROL: Guys. If I could have your attention a…

PUSHY BOB: Ah! "Gaffe"! Five ltters meaning "screw-up___could work.

CAROL: Thank you, Pushy Bob! I wanted to spare everyone's feelings, but there is one more piece of information I need to share with you. The Grant? (puzzled pause.) Remember The Grant? (puzzled pause) The last glint of rescue in an otherwise dark sea of despair?

(HUMAN PUDDLE weeps, a high-pitched sob.)

PUSHY BOB: (A flash.) Oh! Yeah! The grant! (He knocks CAROL'S box off the desk accidentally.) Helping people with our unusual skills!

CAROL: Well. You didn't get the grant.

WABBIT WOMAN: Ooooooooooooooo

THE HUMAN PUDDLE: Oh God! How much rejection do they think we can take?

MASTER OF THE OBVIOUS: Maybe the word "semi-" gave them a pause.

EL GRANDE DE SAYER: You heard me! Quit! We follow Carol on out of here.

CAROL: I walk alone!

MASTER OF THE OBVIOUS: You mean—give up the office.

WABBIT WOMAN: Look. We have to have faith. Faith that somehow our talents, howevah stwange, howevah cweative, howevah--- meager---- amount to

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something. I'm not giving up smoking for nobody. I'll continue to smoke—and smirk— and yes!, snorkel wheorbel I foltb libit.

MASTER OF THE OBVIOUS: Smoke on, wabbit woman!

HUMAN PUDDLE: We just wanted to help people.

PUSHY BOB: Well, what the hell do people want! I mean , excuse me for illuminating the human condition but we do so have something to offer! Can't they see that?!

MASTER OF THE OBVIOUS: Push on, Pushy Bob!

EL GRANDE DE SAYER: No! This is the end. We have to accept that. We have to be big enough to say "yes" to "no!"

(A moment while they all ponder this statement)

MASTER OF THE OBVIOUS: We didn't get our grant.

PUSHY BOB: And who's to blame? (pause) Carol. We'll miss you. You're fired.

CAROL: Thank you, Pushy Bob. Look guys. I'm sorry. But there is such a thing as appreciating the realty of a situation. (pause)

EL GRANDE DE SAYER: Exactly, Carol! Reality! When we walk out that door, We must know who we are, and always will be—unwanted, useless, distracting, irritating, unloved and unlovable strange-ohs. When we walk out that door, We're gonna know we face a world that has no use for us and our hopeless, pathetic little lives!

(EL GRANDE has rested his case. Stunned silence. After a moment, THE HUMAN PUDDLE sobs loudly. A pause)

CAROL: Well. Let me put it this way. I've enjoyed my time here, but I never really understood how smoking and snorkeling and crying and being pushy and telling people what they already know—Or being negative on a

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continual basis—I mean , how are those qualities supposed to help other people? Huh? (pause)

WABBIT WOMAN: OK. It's a little weird. But is that any weason to weject us?!

CAROL: Yes. Yes, it is. (Pause during which lights flicker and then go out) Well, there it is. Reality. Third and final notice from the electric company. Tell ya wha. I'll take the answering machine in lieu of a check(CAROL disconnects the answering machine and tucks it under her arm.) Good luck to all of you. And I really mean that. (CAROL exits)

MASTER OF THE OBVIOUS: She's gone.

EL GRANDE DE SAYER: We don't need her.

PUSHY BOB: She left her crossword puzzle.

WABBIT WOMAN: (sings another chorus of "Raindrops" sadly)

(Long pause. The phone rings. They all look at it. It rings again.)

MASTER OF THE OBVIOUS: Phone's ringing.

HUMAN PUDDLE: Aren't you going to answer it?

EL GRANDE DE SAYER: No.

PUSHY BOB: Just another noxious nincompoop lookin' for a cheap laugh prob'ly (phone rings)

HUMAN PUDDLE: But what if. . .

EL GRANDE DE SAYER: What!!

HUMAN PUDDLE: Well, what if it's a guy in Sault Ste. Marie who's in big trouble 'cause he can't accept what's happening in his life.

MASTER OF THE OBVIOUS: He needs help hearing some hard—but obvious--truths. (phone rings)

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HUMAN PUDDLE: Or, like, what if it's some shy kid in Cheyenne, who never gets picked when they're choosing up teams and never gets called on in class, who always walks home alone.

PUSHY BOB: Maybe all she needs is an assertive role-model, a little jolt of brass, somebody to tell her not to be afraid to just barge in and make it happen. (phone rings)

HUMAN PUDDLE: What if it's a guy in St. Louis who can't say "no" to a boss who keeps making him stay late to work and that's ruining his home life.

EL GRANDE: He needs help, he needs someone who can help him see the importance of saying "NO" emphatically. And often. (Phone rings)

HUMAN PUDDLE: Or maybe it's –uhhh-maybe it's---uhhhh---

WABBIT WOMAN: A synchwonized swim team!—who want a cewtain fashion nostalgia to their swimsuits!—And who despewately need to—learn to—you know— smirk for the judges! (phone rings)

HUMAN PUDDLE: Or maybe, just maybe, it's a bunch of people right here in this city. A group of dreamers who've lost their way. And maybe what they need most of all, maybe they need in fact, is just a darn good—(dissolving in tears)

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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